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Indiana power outage presses on

After 10 days, thousands still left in dark

**By Rebecca Johnson
and Allison Kiehl**
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The newborn baby didn't understand why he was sitting in the dark. As power outages in northwest Indiana dragged on for over a week, Alyssa Casalin said her 2-month-old boy grew increasingly restless. She struggled to see the baby when he cried at night, hoping her flashlight

would turn on. Changing a diaper wasn't easy. Neither was properly storing milk. She drove around frequently during the day. It helped calm her son and allowed her to look for open stores to buy food. But she couldn't be out too long because of long lines at gas stations. "It was just a lot of screaming from him," said Casalin, 19, who lives in Portage. "You got to keep

your composure to be a mom, and you know keep (him) calm because he doesn't know any better." Tens of thousands of others across northwest Indiana have endured more than a week without power since the Aug. 11 storm knocked more than 300,000 Northern Indiana Public Service Co. customers off the grid. Residents say they're rationing gas and, at times, losing faith that the power will ever come back on. Even some celebrities, such as actor George Lopez and food influencer Keith

Lee, have talked about the ongoing struggle for residents. "We have not gotten any help, any updates. No nothing," said Gary resident Antoinette Edwards, 46. "It would be great if someone could communicate and say something, even send out a mass call or text. I feel like we've been left in the dark. I feel like we've been left behind." The outage number jumped Thursday afternoon after electrical wires were observed on the ground near Indianapolis Boulevard and Main Street in Schererville; traffic

signals were out at U.S. 30 and 41 as well. As of 4 p.m. Thursday, NIPSCO's outage tracker listed 68,000 customers who remain without power because of the storms, including 26,880 in Gary, a majority-Black city that's been hit particularly hard. And many may have to keep waiting for days. Power isn't expected to be mostly restored in Gary and Portage until next Tuesday. Munster not until Monday, while Hammond

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US aircraft carrier arrives in Mideast

Washington sent to relieve Lincoln after reports of hardship

**By Ben Finley
and Konstantin Toropin**
ASSOCIATED PRESS

WASHINGTON — The Asia-based USS George Washington aircraft carrier is now operating in the Middle East, the U.S. military said Thursday, relieving a long-deployed carrier after reports of mental health challenges and supply shortages aboard while it was supporting the Iran war. U.S. Central Command, which oversees military operations in the Middle East, said on social media that the carrier arrived in the region Wednesday.

It was not clear when the USS Abraham Lincoln would arrive back in the U.S. or whether it would make a port stop along the way, but the journey takes just over a month.

The Washington arrived as concerns have grown about the Lincoln's lengthy deployment, which has included a record-setting uninterrupted time at sea of more than 250 days, and about reports of crew stress and poor mental health, as well as supply shortages, including food and hygiene products.

Several Democratic lawmakers have pressed the Department of Defense for accountability over conditions aboard the Lincoln, which Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth has said were "completely misrepresented."

Hegseth spoke with the Lincoln's crew last week, and Adm. Brad Cooper, head of U.S. Central Command, visited this past weekend. In an editorial published Sunday by The Wall Street Journal, Cooper said the crew "delivered a performance for the ages, and now you are going home."

Extended deployments of carriers can wear on service members who are away from home for long periods and increase strain on the ship and its equipment. While

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Republican gubernatorial candidate Darren Bailey speaks with supporters during Republican Day at the Illinois State Fair on Wednesday in Springfield. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

MORNING FOG FOR GOP DAY

As Republicans celebrate at Illinois State Fair, weather becomes metaphor for a party short on money and message discipline

By Rick Pearson and Jeremy Gorner | CHICAGO TRIBUNE

SPRINGFIELD — Wednesday morning in the state's capital city opened with dense fog, perhaps an appropriate weather condition for Republicans, who have long struggled to find their way in Illinois, as they celebrated the GOP's day at the State Fair.

Shut out of statewide offices since Bruce Rauner lost the governorship to Democrat JB Pritzker in 2018, and now a minority party bordering on dormancy in Illinois, the GOP used Republican Day to kick off campaigns for its little-known slate in the Nov. 3 election.

That included Secretary of State candidate Diane Harris, who vowed she would require all motorists to be proficient enough in English to read road signs, state comptroller candidate Bryan Drew, who wrongly

said state audits are politically limited in scope and did not know the state auditor general was a constitutional officer, and attorney general contender and frequently unsuccessful candidate Bob Fioretti, who

erroneously contended that Chicago-area immigration raids by federal agents resulted in arrests of only immigrants with criminal backgrounds.

All of that came alongside Springfield businessman and

former state GOP chair Don Tracy, who is seeking the open U.S. Senate seat being vacated by retiring Democratic U.S. Sen. Dick Durbin, reciting a variation of a line from U.S. Sen. John Kennedy of Louisiana: "We Republicans are far from perfect, but the other side is flat-out crazy."

"And I have to add this," Tracy said. "They're getting crazier." Then there was former state Sen. Darren Bailey, in a rematch after losing by nearly 13 percentage points to Democratic Gov. JB Pritzker, suggesting he didn't believe in the widely accepted theory of evolution.

Bailey defended curricula used at the Full Armor Christian Academy, which he founded, that teaches children that dinosaurs and humans walked the earth at the same time. According to scientists, it wasn't until more than 65 million years after the dinosaurs' extinction that the earliest humans walked the earth. Bailey was asked about evolution in response to

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HIGH SCHOOL FOOTBALL

Chicago: Cradle of quarterbacks

As the Illinois high school football season kicks off in earnest Friday, here's a look at reasons why quarterback play in Chicago has been on the upswing. **Sports, C1**



Regulators propose allowing outdoor grown cannabis

Illinois law requires 'enclosed, locked' facility for companies

By Robert McCoppin
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

In a major reversal, Illinois regulators have proposed letting cannabis companies grow cannabis outdoors, a move that would significantly lower energy consumption and cultivation costs — though home growers would be out of luck.

State law requires cannabis to be grown in an "enclosed, locked" facility. Previously, the state Department of Agriculture interpreted that to mean that outdoor growing was prohibited, citing concerns over security and agri-

cultural pesticides drifting into marijuana crops.

But the agency gave in and proposed the change after at least two cannabis companies won court approval for outside grows and a third filed suit to do the same. Outdoor cultivation is common in other states that have legalized cannabis, from California to Michigan. Researchers say it could save up to 76% of the energy used on indoor cultivation, helping the state toward its goal of reducing net carbon emissions. It could also lower prices for consumers.

The founder of the Illinois Independent Craft Growers Association, Scott Redman, said the move would be a "game changer"

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A Chicago resident shows a marijuana plant growing outdoors at her home garden on Wednesday. The resident, who has a medical cannabis card, is currently growing four plants in her backyard to cultivate for personal use. **JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

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